root of the divide is this invented topographical dichotomy. The ethnic division was accentuated by introducing a division of the land through legislation," says Prof. A. Bimol Akoijam of Jawaharlal Nehru University. Tribal status for Meiteis will enable them to buy land in the hills. Kuki voices claim it's a myth that Meiteis cannot do so already. "Otherwise, how come so many Meiteis have homes in hill areas? My Meitei friend from childhood still has her home in Churachandpur," says Hoineilhing Sitlhou, a Kuki, who teaches at the University of Hyderabad. Sominthang Doungel, leader of the Kuki Inpi Manipur (KIM), says though Section 158 of the Manipur Land Revenue and Land Reforms Act, 1960, restricts non-tribals from directly purchasing tribal land, they can do so with the consent of district councils.



"MY CHILDHOOD MEITEI FRIEND NOW SAYS THAT KUKIS ARE POPPY CULTIVATORS, ILLEGAL MIGRANTS. IT IS SO HURTFUL"

HOINEILHING SITLHOU
Asst. Prof., University of Hyderabad



"BOTH ARE VICTIMS AND AGGRESSORS. LET THERE BE DIALOGUE. HALF OF THE PROBLEMS WILL BE SOLVED ONCE WE START LISTENING"

BHAGAT OINAM
Professor, JNU

The other trigger: the Biren Singh regime's drive against encroachers and poppy cultivators in reserved forests. The evictions stem from a November 2022 forest department notification derecognising 38 villages in Churachandpur and Noney districts, which were allegedly located inside the Churachandpur-Khoupum protected forest. The Kukis claim even legitimate residents were evicted. Manipur shares a 400-km border with Myanmar, less than 10 per cent of which is fenced—a natural sieve for drug smuggling. Since 2017, when the BJP came to power, large tracts of poppy fields have been destroyed and alleged encroachers evicted from reserved forests. Most villages affected by this drive are Kuki. This has also resulted in racial stereotyping. "My Meitei friend, who teaches at a university, has written that Kukis are poppy cultivators and illegal immigrants. This is so hurtful. She erased all our childhood memories in one sweeping statement," says Sitlhou.

The 'illegal immigrant' taunt is another bequest of the porous border. Many Myanmar refugees belonging to the Kuki-Chin-Zomi-Mizo ethnic continuum, sharing origins with several hill tribes of Manipur, Mizoram and Nagaland, had fled to these states following counterinsurgency operations by the junta there. Due to this, claim Meitei groups, new villages emerged in reserved forests. A government source claims 996 new villages have come up in three Kuki-dominated districts—Tengnoupal, Chandel and Churachandpur—since 2006. This hardened anti-Kuki sentiment, with Meitei groups demanding a population commission and the implementation of the National Register of Citizens (NRC). They cite an unnatural population boom in the hills where the decadal growth rate in the 2011 Census was recorded as 40 per cent, as against a mere 16 per cent in the valley. The CM too has publicly blamed "Myanmar immigrants" for the deforestation and drug menace. He even formed a cabinet subcommittee to detect illegal immigrants—interestingly, it is headed by tribal affairs minister Letpao Haokip, a Kuki.

Religion further bedevils the situation. The spread of Christianity is resented by Meiteis, who claim missionaries have converted a section of their brethren. Between 1961 and 2011, the share of Hindus in the state declined from 62 per cent to 41 per cent, while Christians rose from 19 per cent to 41 per cent. The conflict has so far seen 221 churches and 17 temples razed. Observers, however, say few Kuki churches were targeted. "More than 150 of these were Meitei churches. It's a response against increasing Christianisation in rural areas...disrupting traditional Meitei culture," says Prof. Oinam.

Biren Singh's return to power last year was attributed to, inter alia, his outreach programme 'Go to Hills'—aimed at delivering welfare schemes to hill areas. Even so, there has been no dearth of efforts to replace him. In April, several BJP MLAs, most of them Kuki, arrived in Delhi, exhorting the central leadership to replace the CM. Four BJP legislators also quit in April. The CM's handling of the current situation—which his detractors claim favours the Meiteis—has hardly been exemplary, but it has consolidated his position as the No. 1 Meitei leader. Though many have demanded his ouster, the BJP can't afford to be at a disadvantage in 40 valley seats.

For now, the BJP's top priority is bringing peace back. It's an uphill task, says a senior army officer, for mistrust between the two sides is complete and all channels of communication have broken down. Sitlhou says some form of separate administration is the only way forward. "I can't go back to Imphal without feeling unsafe. Many of my Kuki friends cannot imagine living next to Meiteis again," she says. (The Centre rules out any such move.) Prof. Oinam believes peace depends on how early the communities can sit down for talks. "Let there be dialogue. Both sides are aggressors and victims. It's important to hear each other out. Half the problems will be solved once we start listening," he says. Social and political leaders must initiate this listening process. ■